

Kannada, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Kannada one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Kannada letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ and learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Kannada simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Kannada is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit. Its own personality shows in one contrast, drawn again and again in these pages: where its oldest sister **Tamil** guards its native word-stock, Kannada borrowed *freely* from Sanskrit. So “hello” is the Sanskrit ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (namaskāra) — yet “no” and “okay” are the native Dravidian ಇಲ್ಲ (illa) and ಸರಿ (sari), shared almost unchanged with Tamil. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Kannada out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Kannada greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Kannada script and how Kannada sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

1.1 ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (namaskāra) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Kannada reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ನ na, ಮ ma, ರ ra. A **vowel sign** changes that vowel: ಕ ka + the long-“ā” sign → ಕಾ kā. And a vowel-less consonant **stacks under** the next as a conjunct (*ottakṣara*): ಸ loses its vowel and tucks under ka → ಸ್ಕ “ska.” Read ನ·ಮ·ಸ್·ಕಾ·ರ → namaskāra.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (namaskāra) is **not** native Kannada — it is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow, homage”) + *kāra* (“a making,” from the root *kr*, “to do”) = “the making of a bow.” The very same word as Hindi *namaskār*. Where its sister Tamil kept a home-grown greeting (*vaṇakkam*), Kannada borrowed freely from Sanskrit — the theme of this whole book.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Kannada	ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ <i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Tamil alone kept its own word; the rest lean on the Sanskrit *namas-*.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello and goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

1.2 ಧನ್ಯವಾದ (*dhanyavāda*) — “thank you,” an utterance of “worthy”

The letters in this word

New: ಧ *dha* (an **aspirated** *d* — a puff of breath), and the conjunct ನ್ಯ (*na* stacked with *ya* → “*nya*”). ವಾ is *vā*. Read ಧನ್ಯವಾದ → *dhanyavāda*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಧನ್ಯವಾದ (*dhanyavāda*) is **Sanskrit**: *dhanya* (“worthy, blessed,” from *dhana*, “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a saying,” root *vad*, “to speak”) = “an utterance of ‘[you are] worthy.’” The same word as Hindi *dhanyavād* and Telugu *dhanyavādamulu*.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Kannada	ಧನ್ಯವಾದ <i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit — same word
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i>	Sanskrit — same word
Tamil	<i>nanri</i>	native (“goodness”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	native — Tamil’s cousin

A stark split: Kannada, Telugu, Hindi take the Sanskrit word; Tamil and Malayalam keep native *nanri* / *nandi*.

1.3 ಹೌದು (*haudu*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ಹೌ is *hau* (ಹ *ha* with the “au” vowel sign hugging it); ದು is *du* (ದ *da* with the “u” sign beneath). Read ಹೌ·ದು → *haudu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೌದು (*haudu*) is the everyday “yes / that’s so” — a genuinely **native** Kannada word, after two Sanskrit loans.

Grammar Lens

Like its sister Tamil, Kannada often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *bandiddīyā?* (“have you come?”), a natural yes is *bandiddēne* (“I have come”). Bank *haudu* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb — a habit shared across the Dravidian family.

1.4 ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) — “no,” a word Tamil shares almost exactly

The letters in this word

ಇ is the **independent vowel** “i” (word-initial, so a full letter). ಲ್ಲ is “lla” — ಲ *la* vowel-stripped and stacked under another *la*, a held “ll.” Read ಇಲ್ಲ → *illa*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) is built on the old Dravidian root *il*, “not-being” — so, like Tamil *illai*, it really means “[it] is not, [there] is not,” serving as the everyday “no.” Its positive twin is ಇದೆ (*ide*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Dravidian negates by *being*. Where English inserts *not*, Kannada — exactly like Tamil — swaps in the negative verb of existence: *pustaka ide* (“there *is* a book”) → *pustaka illa* (“there *is not* a book”). A shared inheritance: Tamil *illai*, Kannada *illa*, Malayalam *illa* — one family, one way to say a thing is not.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Kannada	ಇಲ್ಲ <i>illa</i>	native (root <i>il</i>)
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Malayalam	<i>illa</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i>	native, a different root
Hindi	<i>nahīnī</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

1.5 ಸರಿ (*sari*) — “okay,” shared whole with Tamil**The letters in this word**

ಸ is *sa*; ರಿ is *ri* (ರ *ra* with the “i” sign). No conjunct here — two clean, round syllables. Read ಸ·ರಿ → *sari*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಸರಿ (*sari*) is native Dravidian for “correct, even, right,” and so “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Kannada. It is the *same word* as Tamil *sari* — identical in sound and meaning, only the script differs; doubled, *sari sari* means “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One shared word, two scripts. *sari* is identical in Kannada and Tamil in sound and meaning — only the letters differ (Kannada writes it ಸರಿ, Tamil in its own script). Watching a shared word change its clothes but not its sound is the fastest way to feel how close these languages are — the pattern-matching that carries you across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam.

1.6 Recap, and how Kannada says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ	<i>namaskāra</i>	hello	Sanskrit
ಧನ್ಯವಾದ	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	thank you	Sanskrit
ಹೌದು	<i>haudu</i>	yes	native
ಇಲ್ಲ	<i>illa</i>	no / isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ಸರಿ	<i>sari</i>	okay	native (= Tamil <i>sari</i>)

The pattern is already visible: the two greeting/politeness words are Sanskrit loans; the three everyday grammar words are native Dravidian, two of them shared almost unchanged with Tamil.

Why it's said this way

The same “go and come back” as Tamil. Kannada, too, avoids a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*hōgi baruttēne*), “having gone, I [will] come [back],” and the reply is ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ (*hōgi banni*), “go, and come back.” The very worldview you met in Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn*: never simply depart — promise a return.

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *nanna hesaru...* (“my name...”) — and Kannada’s *nīnu* / *nīvu* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಅರುಣ್. (nanna hesaru Arun — “My name is Arun.”)
ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? (nimma hesaru ēnu — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled.

2.1 ಹೆಸರು (*hesaru*) — “name,” and the *p*-to-*h* shift

The letters in this word

ಹ (*ha*) + ೆ (the *e*-sign) → ಹೆ (*he*); ಸ (*sa*); ರು (*ru*). Read ಹೆ·ಸ·ರು → *hesaru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೆಸರು (*hesaru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *pesar — and it hides a famous Kannada sound-law: an old initial *p* became *h*. So *pesar → *hesar → *hesaru*. That makes it a *cousin* of Tamil *peyar* (same root; Tamil kept the *p*, Kannada softened it to *h*) — and, like *peyar*, *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). The Dravidian south kept its own word for “name.”

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Kannada	ಹೆಸರು <i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian *pesar (p→h)
Tamil	<i>peyar</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root (kept <i>p</i>)
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

The $p \rightarrow h$ shift is why *hesaru* looks unlike its sisters — but it is the same word.

2.2 ನನ್ನ (*nanna*) — “my”

The letters in this word

ನ (*na*) + the conjunct ನ್ನ (*nn*) → *nanna* — a doubled, held *nn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನನ್ನ (*nanna*, “my”) is the possessive of ನಾನು (*nānu*, “I”) — native Dravidian, on the pronoun stem *nān, the same one behind Tamil *nān* / *en*. It has no Indo-European cousin: the Dravidian “I/my” is a different word from the European *I/my*.

2.3 ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ... (*nanna hesaru ...*) — “my name is...”

ನನ್ನ (my) + ಹೆಸರು (name) + name = **nanna hesaru ...** *Nanna hesaru Arun.*
= “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is.” As in Tamil, notice there is *no* verb: Kannada sets “my name” beside “Arun” and lets the “is” be understood — the **zero copula** of the Dravidian family. *Nanna hesaru Arun* = literally “my name Arun.”

2.4 ನೀನು / ನೀವು (*nīnu* / *nīvu*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

ನೀ (*nī*) + ನು (*nu*) → *nīnu*; ನೀ + ವು (*vu*) → *nīvu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನೀನು (*nīnu*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — the same native root as Tamil *nī*. ನೀವು (*nīvu*) is the respectful/plural “you.”

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, once more. *nīnu* (familiar) vs. *nīvu* (respectful, and literally plural) — the same politeness-by-plural as Tamil *nīṇṇaḷ* and French *vous*. For a first meeting, *nīvu*.

2.5 ಏನು (*ēnu*) — “what”

The letters in this word

ಏ (independent long *ē*, word-initial) + ನು (*nu*) → *ēnu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಏನು (*ēnu*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-* / **e-* — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *enna*, heading Kannada’s question family: *ēnu* (what), *yāru* (who), *elli* (where), *yāke* (why).

2.6 ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? — “what’s your name?”

ನಿಮ್ಮ (*nimma*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīvu* (“you,” respectful). So ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no “is.”* Three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Nanna hesaru Arun*. The familiar “your” is *ninna* (from *nīnu*): *ninna hesaru ēnu*?

2.7 ಸಂತೋಷ (santōṣa) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is ನಿಮ್ಮನ್ನು ಭೇಟಿಯಾಗಿ ಸಂತೋಷ (nimmannu bhēṭiyāgi santōṣa) — “**having met you, joy.**” But note the key word: ಸಂತೋಷ (santōṣa, “joy, contentment”) is **Sanskrit** (*sam-* “fully” + *toṣa* “satisfaction”), not native. Where Tamil reaches for its home-grown *magilcci*, Kannada — true to form — uses a Sanskrit word even for “pleased.” The same split you saw over “hello” and “thanks” runs right through the introductions.

2.8 The whole exchange

Kannada		English
ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಮೀರಾ.	<i>nanna hesaru Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು?	<i>nimma hesaru ēnu</i>	What’s your name?
ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಅರುಣ್.	<i>nanna hesaru Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
ಸಂತೋಷ.	<i>santōṣa</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *hesaru* (Dravidian *pesar, p→h; *not name*), *nanna* (from *nānu*, “I”), *ēnu* (Dravidian question-stem) — and *santōṣa*, a Sanskrit loan for “pleased,” the family thread again. The Kannada habit to keep: the **zero copula** (no “is”). Next chapter: *hēgiddīra*? (“how are you?”) and answering with *chennāgiddēne* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — carried by the Dravidian verb “to be”:

ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? (nīvu hēgiddīrā — “How are you?”)
ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ, ಧನ್ಯವಾದ. (nānu cennāgiddēne, dhanyavāda — “I’m well, thank you.”)

3.1 ಹೇಗೆ (hēge) — “how,” another of the ē- questions

The letters in this word

ಹೇ (hē) + ಗೆ (ge) → ಹೇಗೆ (hēge).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೇಗೆ (hēge, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base ē-/yā- from ēnu. Kannada gathers its questions here: ēnu (what), hēge (how), yāru (who), elli (where), yāvāga (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* and Telugu’s *elā* — a family older than the Sanskrit words Kannada otherwise borrows so readily.

3.2 ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? — “how are you?”

The new word is ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ (hēgiddīrā): hēge (“how”) fused with the verb ಇರು (iru, “to be, exist, stay”) + the respectful-you ending. So ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? is “you how are?”, the verb last, as in every Kannada sentence. The verb *iru*

is the very same native Dravidian “to be” that Tamil uses — and (Chapter 5) the verb for “I live.”

Grammar Lens

The verb carries “you.” The ending already means “you (respectful),” so *nīvu* can be dropped. To a friend: ನೀನು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀಯಾ? (*nīnu hēgiddīyā?*). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

3.3 ನಾನು (*nānu*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ನಾ (*nā*) + ನು (*nu*) → ನಾನು (*nānu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಾನು (*nānu*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian *yāṇ / *nāṇ — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *maiṇ*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the ನನ್ನ (*nanna*, “my”) you met in Chapter 2. Kannada borrows Sanskrit freely for higher vocabulary, but its bedrock pronouns stayed Dravidian.

3.4 ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ (*cennāgi*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ಚೆ (*ce* — the letter ಚ is “ch as in *cheese*”) + ನ್ನಾ (*nnā*) + ಗಿ (*gi*) → ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ (*cennāgi*, “well, nicely”) is native Dravidian, from ಚೆನ್ನು (*cennu*, “good, beautiful”) + the adverb-maker *-āgi* (“in a ... way”) — so it means, at heart, “in a beautiful way.” The root *cennu* is pure Kannada, no Sanskrit or European cousin.

Fuse it with *īru*: ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ (*nānu cennāgiddēne*) — “I am well.”

3.5 ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ (*paravāgilla*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ means “it does not matter / there is no harm” — *paravā* (“harm”) + ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*, “is-not”), the Chapter-1 negative. It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) is Kannada’s “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across **Kannada, Tamil, and Malayalam** — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu* (so Telugu’s “no problem” is *paravāledu*, Kannada’s *paravāgilla*).

Grammar Lens

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *duḍḍu illa* (“there’s no money”). Hold *iru* / *illa* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Kannada	English
ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ?	How are you?
ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ, ಧನ್ಯವಾದ.	I'm well, thank you.
ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ.	No problem / you're welcome.

Every atom is traced. *Hēge* belongs to the native *ē*- question family; *nānu* is Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*; and *cennāgi* means “beautifully.” The *iru* / *illa* pair supplies “is” and “is-not,” with *illa* shared by Tamil and Malayalam. Next chapter: the farewells — and Kannada, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Kannada, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ. (*hōgi baruttēne* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.1 ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*) — “go,” and ಬಾ (come)

The letters in this word

ಹೋ (*hō*) + ಗು (*gu*) → ಹೋಗು. Its partner ಬಾ (*bā*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*, “to go”) and ಬಾ (*bā*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs. As commands they are whole words: *hōgu!* (“go!”), *bā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Kannada’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*hōgi baruttēne*) — “I’ll go and come back”

ಹೋಗಿ (*hōgi*, “having gone”) + ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*baruttēne*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Kannada speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ (*hōgi banni*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varām</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

4.3 ನಾಳೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ (*nāḷe sigōṇa*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

ನಾಳೆ (*nāḷe*): ನಾ (*nā*) + ಳೆ (*ḷe*, retroflex ಳ *ḷ*). ಸಿಗೋಣ (*sigōṇa*) = *sigu* (“meet”) + *-ōṇa* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಾಳೆ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native, from *nāl* (“day”) — the same root as Tamil’s *nālai*. ಸಿಗು (*sigu*, “to meet, be found”) gives *sigōṇa* (“let’s meet”) — “tomorrow, let’s meet.” The *-ōṇa* ending is Kannada’s warm “let’s ...”: *hōgōṇa* (“let’s go”).

4.4 ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ = ಮತ್ತೆ (*matte*, “again”) + *sigōṇa* (“let’s meet”). Both are native Dravidian: *matte* (“again”) and *sigu* (“to meet”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi*, Kannada keeps the native *sigu* — the same phrase, from home-grown stock.

4.5 The farewells

Kannada	English
ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ.	Go and come back. (the reply)
ನಾಳೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ.	See you tomorrow.
ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *hōgu/bā* (go/come), *nāle* (“tomorrow” ← *nāl* “day,” shared with Tamil), and *sigu* (“meet,” native — where Tamil borrowed *sandi*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nānu kannada mātanāḍuttēne* — and Kannada’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Kannada’s sentences begin to move:

ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ. (*nānu kannaḍa mātanāḍuttēne* — “I speak Kannada.”)

5.1 ಮಾತನಾಡು (*mātanāḍu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ಮಾ (*mā*) + ತೆ (*ta*) + ನಾ (*nā*) + ಡು (*ḍu*) → ಮಾತನಾಡು.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಾತನಾಡು (*mātanāḍu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian, built on ಮಾತು (*mātu*, “word, speech”). To say “I speak,” Kannada stacks two endings on the stem — tense then person:

$mātanāḍ-$ + $-utt-$ (present) + $-ēne$ (“I”) → ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ
(*mātanāḍuttēne*), “I speak.”

The $-ēne$ ending is “I,” so *nānu* is rarely needed: *mātanāḍuttāne* (he), *mātanāḍuttāle* (she), *mātanāḍuttāre* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Kannada verb is built this way. And, like Tamil and Telugu, Kannada marks **no gender in the first person**: *mātanāḍuttēne* is the same for a man or a woman.

5.2 ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ — “I speak Kannada”

ನಾನು (I) + ಕನ್ನಡ (*kannāḍa*, the object) + ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ (speak) — “I Kannada speak,” verb last. The name ಕನ್ನಡ (*kannāḍa*) is native, often linked to *kar-nāḍu* (“the high/black land,” whence *Karnataka*). Kannada has a literature over a thousand years old and a store of classical honours — a classical tongue of some fifty million speakers.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Mātanāḍuttēne* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Kannada, like Tamil and Telugu, marks no gender in the first or second person (only the third: *-āne* he, *-āle* she).

5.3 ಇರು (*iru*) — “to be, to stay, to live”**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

ಇರು (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay, live”) is native Dravidian — the very same *iru* Tamil uses, and the verb behind Chapter 3’s *hēgiddirā* (“how are you”) and *cennāgiddēne* (“I’m well”). It also means “to reside”: ನಾನು ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ ಇದ್ದೇನೆ (*nānu Beṅgalūrinalli iddēne*, “I live in Bangalore”). One verb covers “be,” “stay,” and “live.”

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ (*Beṅgalūrinalli*) = *Beṅgalūru* + *-alli* (“in”), glued to the *end* of the noun. Kannada uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes): “Bangalore-in I am,” the verb last.

5.4 ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡು (*kelasa māḍu*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಾಡು (*māḍu*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Kannada — like Hindi with *karnā*, Tamil with *sey*, and Telugu with *cēyu* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡು (*kelasa māḍu*, “work-do” = “to work”), *aḍuge māḍu* (“to cook”), *sahāya māḍu* (“to help,” with a **Sanskrit** noun on the **native** *māḍu*). So “I work” is ನಾನು ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ (*nānu kelasa māḍuttēne*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + ಮಾಡು = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*,” Tamil’s “noun + *sey*,” and Telugu’s “noun + *cēyu*.” Four languages, two from an unrelated family, all landed on the same trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Kannada	English
ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I speak Kannada.
ನಾನು ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ ಇದ್ದೇನೆ.	I live in Bangalore.
ನಾನು ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *mā-tanāḍu* (speak ← *mātu* “word”), *iru* (be/stay/live, with *-alli* “in” on the noun’s end), and *māḍu* (do → *kelasa māḍu* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*). From here, Kannada’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I know Kannada the way Kannada itself says it — with no subject at all, marking myself with the dative -ge.

Say ನನಗೆ ಕನ್ನಡ ಗೊತ್ತು — “to-me Kannada known” — set against ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ, then line up the four Dravidian datives -ge · -ukku · -ku · -ikku.

6.1 -ಗೆ (-ge) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front**, as a separate word. Kannada sticks it on the **back** — the biggest structural fact about the language, in one suffix.

You’ll want to know: Adding it on

word	+ -ge	meaning
ಹೆಸರು <i>hesaru</i> — name	ಹೆಸರ ^{ಗೆ} <i>hesarige</i>	to/for the name
ಕೆಲಸ <i>kelasa</i> — work	ಕೆಲಸಕ್ಕೆ <i>kelasakke</i>	for work

Two shapes, one suffix: **-ige** after some stems, **-kke** after others. Kannada adjusts it to fit the word in front — but you can still see exactly where the noun stops and the ending starts.

And with “I”, which reshapes first:

ನಾನು *nānu* (“I”) → ನನಗೆ *nanage* (“to me”)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

All four descend from one Proto-Dravidian dative, **-k(k)u**. Look at what became of its *k*:

language	dative
Tamil	-ukku
Telugu	-ku / -ki
Malayalam	-ikku / -inu
Kannada	-ge / -ige

Kannada is the one that **voiced** it — *k* → *g* between vowels — and carried that change into the dative, where its sisters kept the hard consonant. Note the other Kannada form, **-kke**: a **doubled** consonant resists voicing, so the geminate preserved the original *k*. The two Kannada shapes are the same suffix caught on either side of a sound change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hesaru ... hesarige”
- “nānu ... nanage” — “I” ... “to me”
- “kelasakke” — “for work,” from Ch. 5’s ಕೆಲಸ
- the family — “-ukku · -ku · -ge · -ikku”

Before you move on

What does **-ಗೆ** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (ನನಗೆ *nanage*.) Why does Kannada have *g* where its sisters have *k*? (Kannada **voiced** the *k* between vowels; doubled **-kke** resisted and kept the old hard form.)

6.2 -ಗೆ — one suffix, one job

You can now attach **-ಗೆ** and make ನನಗೆ “to me.” Look at what that visible seam tells you about how Kannada builds longer words.

Grammar Lens: Stacking versus fusion

	Kannada -ge	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — first or second
can you see the seam?	yes: <i>hesar + ige</i>	no — one fused lump

Kannada **stacks** suffixes. Each suffix carries one meaning and sits in a fixed order, so the learner can see where the noun ends and the case marker begins. That is what **agglutinative** means here: longer words are assembled from pieces whose jobs remain visible.

Latin **fuses** several jobs into one ending. *-īs* carries case, plural number, and declension class at once—and it does not even settle whether the case is dative or ablative. Kannada **-ŕ** carries one unambiguous job: “to/for.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hesar + ige* — a visible noun-plus-case seam
- Kannada *-ge* — one job, dative
- Latin *-īs* — case, plural, and declension fused

Before you move on

Why is Kannada called agglutinative? (**It stacks visible pieces, each with one job.**) How many jobs can Latin *-īs* fuse? (**Case, number, and declension class—and its case can still be dative or ablative.**)

6.3 ನನಗೆ ಕನ್ನಡ ಗೊತ್ತು — “I know Kannada”

Chapter 5 gave you ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ — “I speak Kannada” — with the verb ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ. Now say “I **know** Kannada.” Kannada will not let you use *nānu*.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

ನನಗೆ ಕನ್ನಡ ಗೊತ್ತು. *nanage kannada gottu*. literally: “**to-me** Kannada [is] **known**.”

piece

ನನಗೆ <i>nanage</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
ಕನ್ನಡ <i>kannada</i>	Kannada (Ch. 5)
ಗೊತ್ತು <i>gottu</i>	“known”

Two things to notice. **You are not the subject** — *nānu* is gone, moved into the dative, leaving *kannada* as the unmarked word the sentence is about. And *gottu* isn’t really a verb doing an action; it’s closer to “[is] **known**.” So nothing in this sentence is *doing* anything at all.

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Kannada separates what you **do** from what **happens to** you. Speaking is an action, so Ch. 5 used *nānu*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive**. Kannada marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Kannada frames it as
I know Kannada	Kannada is known to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me

English keeps one fossil of the same idea: “**methinks**” — where *me* is a dative, “it seems **to me**.” Kannada made it a rule.

Grammar Lens: All four sisters do it

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Tamil	<i>enakku tamil teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

One construction, four languages, four suffixes that are visibly the **same suffix** — Kannada’s *g* being the softened *k* of the others. The Dravidian family showing its bones, exactly as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nanage kannada gottu*”
- the contrast — “*nānu kannada mātanāḍuttēne*” (I speak) ... “*nanage kannada gottu*” (known to me)
- the literal — “to-me Kannada known”
- the four cousins — “*-ge · -ukku · -ku · -ikku*”

Before you move on

What does ನನಗೆ ಕನ್ನಡ ಗೊತ್ತು literally say? (“**To-me** Kannada **known**.”) What has English got that Kannada hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nānu* is replaced by the dative *nanage*.) Is *gottu* an action verb? (**No** — it’s “[is] known”; nothing is doing anything.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens to** you.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to ten in Kannada and read the Kannada digits ೦–೧೦ off the page.

Count ಒಂದು through ಹತ್ತು aloud, read the digits ೬ ೭ ೮ ೯ ೧೦, and hear the p → h shift that turns Tamil pattu into Kannada hattu.

7.1 ಒಂದು, ಎರಡು, ಮೂರು, ನಾಲ್ಕು, ಐದು — one to five

If you walked here through Tamil, you already know these numbers — Kannada just says them with its own accent.

You’ll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
1	೦	ಒಂದು	<i>ondu</i>
2	೧	ಎರಡು	<i>eraḍu</i>
3	೨	ಮೂರು	<i>māru</i>
4	೩	ನಾಲ್ಕು	<i>nālku</i>
5	೪	ಐದು	<i>aidu</i>

The single symbols ೦ ೧ ೨ ೩ ೪ ೫ are Kannada’s own digits — you’ll meet them on bus numbers and prices, distinct from the words above.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

These are **native Dravidian** numbers, not Sanskrit borrowings — the same word-stock Tamil kept. Line them up against Tamil and they are plainly the same word wearing a Kannada coat:

	Tamil	Kannada
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	eraḍu
3	<i>mūṇru</i>	mūru
4	<i>nāṅku</i>	nāḷku
5	<i>aintu</i>	aidu
One is the family’s odd number: Tamil <i>onru</i> and Kannada <i>ondu</i> are cousins (from an old <i>on-</i>), but Telugu will break rank with <i>okaṭi</i> when you get there. So learn <i>ondu</i> now, but expect Telugu’s “one” to surprise you.		

Grammar Lens: A Kannada habit to notice

The **anusvara** — the small circle ◌◌ in ಒಂದು (*on-du*) — is a nasal that takes its colour from the letter after it: an *n* before *d* in *ondu*, an *m* before *b* later in *ombattu* (nine). One mark, whatever nasal the next consonant needs. You’ll see it constantly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ondu, eraḍu, mūru, nāḷku, aidu*”
- the Tamil→Kannada shift — “*iraṇṭu* → *eraḍu*”, same number, new coat
- read the digits — ೧ ೨ ೩ ೪ ೫

Before you move on

Count to five in Kannada. (*Ondu, eraḍu, mūru, nāḷku, aidu.*) Are these borrowed from Sanskrit? (**No** — native Dravidian, shared with Tamil.) Which number will Telugu form differently? (**One** — *okaṭi*, vs Kannada *ondu.*) What does the ◌◌ anusvara do in *ondu*? (Stands for the nasal the next consonant needs — here *n* before *d*.) Next: six to ten.

7.2 ಆರು, ಏಳು, ಎಂಟು, ಒಂಬತ್ತು, ಹತ್ತು — six to ten

Five more — and the last one shows the single sound-change that most makes Kannada *sound* like Kannada.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
6	೬	ಆರು	<i>āru</i>
7	೭	ಏಳು	<i>ēlu</i>
8	೮	ಎಂಟು	<i>eṇṭu</i>
9	೯	ಒಂಬತ್ತು	<i>ombattu</i>
10	೧೦	ಹತ್ತು	<i>hattu</i>

(Ten needs two digits — ೧೦, a one and a zero — just like 10.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Put ten beside Tamil:

Tamil **pattu** → Kannada **hattu**.

Kannada systematically softened an old word-initial **p-** into **h-**. It isn't a one-off: it runs right through the language —

	Tamil	Kannada
ten	<i>pattu</i>	hattu
milk	<i>pāl</i>	hālu
tooth	<i>pal</i>	hallu

Once you know the rule, a Kannada *h-* word often hands you its Tamil cousin for free: hide the *h-*, restore a *p-*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six and seven stay close cousins (Tamil *āru* / Kannada *āru*; Tamil *ēlu* / Kannada *ēlu* — note Kannada hardened Tamil's rare **l** into an ordinary retroflex **ḷ**). **Eight and nine** wander more: Kannada *eṇṭu* and *ombattu* are still relatives of Tamil *eṇṭu* and *onpatu*, but **Telugu** leaves the family entirely there (*enimidi*, *tommidi*) — so treat 8–9 as the loose cells.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēḷu, eṇṭu, ombattu, hattu”
- the shift — “pattu → hattu”, “pāl → hālu”: hide the h, find the p
- read the digits — ೬ ೭ ೮ ೯ ೧೦

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Kannada. (*Āru, ēḷu, eṇṭu, ombattu, hattu.*) What regular shift turns Tamil *pattu* into Kannada *hattu*? (Word-initial **p-** → **h-** — also *pāl* → *hālu*.) What happened to Tamil’s rare **ḷ** in Kannada *ēḷu*? (It hardened into an ordinary retroflex **ḷ̣**.) Which numbers should you trust least as family cousins? (**Eight and nine** — Telugu especially wanders.)

Chapter 8

Please

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Kannada, and use the polite verb ending Kannada reaches for far more often than the word itself.

Build ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು out of daya (“compassion”) + iṭṭu (“having placed”), then make the everyday polite request instead: ಕುಳಿತುಕೊಳ್ಳಿ, “please sit.”

8.1 ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು (dayaviṭṭu) — please (having placed compassion)

Kannada’s everyday “please” is, once you open it up, a small act of generosity: “having **placed** compassion” between us.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು = **please**, literally “**having placed compassion / kindness.**” Two pieces:

- ದಯ (daya) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit daya.
- ಇಟ್ಟು (iṭṭu) = “**having placed / set down,**” from the verb ಇಡು (idu) “to place, to put.”

So dayaviṭṭu means, at heart, *setting kindness down (before you)* — asking the listener to act from compassion.

That is exactly how **Tamil** builds it (*tayavu seytu*, “**do** the kindness”), and the same instinct as **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and

Hindi *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”). A wide arc of Asia says *please* by naming the kindness it hopes for.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

daya + a light verb, four times over:

- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

Why it’s said this way

The honest note: a standalone please-word is a little **formal / emphatic**. Everyday Kannada politeness leans on the **respectful command** — the verb ending *-i* (ಕುಳಿತುಕೊಳ್ಳಿ *kulitukolli* “please sit,” ಹೇಳಿ *hēḷi* “please tell me.” That ending already means “please” do this. Add ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು in front when you want to underline the courtesy.

The letters in this word

Look at ಟ್ಟು — a **doubled** *t*. The first ಟ್ is *ta* silenced by the **virama** (its vowel cut), and it tucks **under** the next letter as an *ottu* (a subscript form) before ಟು *tu*. Kannada writes a double consonant by stacking, not repeating side by side — a neat contrast with how the Roman alphabet just writes “tt.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “daya” — compassion — then “iṭṭu,” having placed
- the whole word — “dayaviṭṭu” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “kulitukolli” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Kannada word for please? (ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu*.) What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “**having placed**” *iṭṭu*.) Which cousins ask the same way? (**Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam** with *daya* — plus **Arabic** *faḍl*, **Hindi** *krpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (**The respectful verb ending** -ಇ -*i*.)

Chapter 9

Sorry

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Kannada and ask someone to forgive me.

Say ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ, trace it back through kṣamisu to Sanskrit kṣamā, and contrast it with Tamil's unrelated maṇṇikkavum.

9.1 ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ (kṣamisi) — forgive me / sorry

You already know ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು, “please.” Kannada’s “sorry” reuses a trick you’ll see everywhere in this language: taking a Sanskrit noun and turning it into a working Kannada verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- ಕ್ಷಮಾ (kṣamā) = “patience, forbearance, forgiveness” — a Sanskrit noun, unchanged.
- -ಇಸು (-isu) = a **verb-making suffix**: bolt it onto a Sanskrit noun and you get a brand-new Kannada verb. kṣamā + -isu → ಕ್ಷಮಿಸು (kṣamisu), “to forgive.” (The same move builds ಪ್ರಾರಂಭಿಸು prārambhisu, “to begin,” from Sanskrit prārambha.)
- -ಃ (-i) = the plain **imperative** ending — the very one you met on ಕುಲಿತುಕೊಲ್ಲಿ (kūlitukolli “please sit”) in the please lesson.

So ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ is simply “**forgive!**” — kṣamisu wearing its imperative ending.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Three of the four Dravidian cousins build “sorry” from the very same Sanskrit noun, each with its own verb-making suffix and its own imperative shape:

- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-isu** (verb) + **-i** (imperative)
- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamiṇcaṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṇcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkanaṁ* — Sanskrit *kṣama* + **-ikkuka** (verb) + **-aṇaṁ** (necessitative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *maṇṇikkavum* — its **own** native root *maṇṇi*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it’s said this way

ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ is a genuine, everyday way to say “sorry” — not overly formal — but in casual conversation you’ll also hear the softer ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ ಬಿಡಿ (*kṣamisi biḍi*, roughly “just forgive [it]”) or simply the borrowed English “**sorry**,” which is extremely common in spoken Kannada.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kṣamā*” — the Sanskrit noun, patience/forgiveness
- the verb — “*kṣamisu*,” to forgive — then “*kṣamisi*,” forgive!
- contrast — Tamil’s *maṇṇikkavum* uses its own root instead

Before you move on

What is ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ built from? (**Sanskrit** *kṣamā* “forgiveness” + the verb-making suffix **-isu** + the imperative **-i**.) Which cousin languages do the same trick, and which one doesn’t? (**Telugu and Malayalam** also verb-ify *kṣamā*; **Tamil** uses its own native root *maṇṇi* instead.) What do people often say casually instead? (**Kṣamisi biḍi**, or simply borrowed English “**sorry**.”)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

By the end of this chapter: I can name any day of the week in Kannada, including the Sunday that uses a different sun-name from Hindi's.

Run Somavāra through Śanivāra, then name Sunday ಭಾನುವಾರ and say why it is Bhānu here where Hindi says Ravi.

10.1 ಸೋಮವಾರ to ಭಾನುವಾರ — the Sanskrit week

Unlike Tamil and Malayalam, Kannada's week is built entirely from Sanskrit — the same recipe as Hindi's. But even here, one day picks a **different** Sanskrit word than Hindi does.

You'll want to know: The pattern: [deity] + ವಾರ, “day”

Kannada	deity/planet	day
ಸೋಮವಾರ (<i>Somavāra</i>)	Moon (Soma)	Monday
ಮಂಗಳವಾರ (<i>Maṅgalavāra</i>)	Mars (Maṅgala)	Tuesday
ಬುಧವಾರ (<i>Budhavāra</i>)	Mercury (Budha)	Wednesday
ಗುರುವಾರ (<i>Guruvāra</i>)	Jupiter (Guru/Bṛhaspati)	Thursday
ಶುಕ್ರವಾರ (<i>Śukravāra</i>)	Venus (Śukra)	Friday
ಶನಿವಾರ (<i>Śanivāra</i>)	Saturn (Śani)	Saturday
ಭಾನುವಾರ (<i>Bhānuvāra</i>)	the Sun (Bhānu, “light, splendor”)	Sunday

Five of these are identical in shape to Hindi’s — same deity, same **-vāra/-vār** ending. **Sunday** is the interesting exception: where Hindi says रविवार (*Ravivār*, from *Ravi*, “sun”), Kannada says ಭಾನುವಾರ (*Bhānuvāra*), built on a **different** Sanskrit word for the sun — **Bhānu**, “light, splendor,” rather than *Ravi*. Sanskrit has **many** names for the sun, and different languages downstream picked different ones for their week.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Somavāra, Maṅgalavāra, Budhavāra, Guruvāra, Śukravāra, Śanivāra” — Monday through Saturday
- the different one — “Bhānuvāra,” Sunday
- the contrast — Hindi says Ravivāra (*Ravi*), Kannada says Bhānuvāra (*Bhānu*) — two different Sanskrit sun-names

Before you move on

What ending does every Kannada weekday share, and where’s it from? (**-ವಾರ** *-vāra*, Sanskrit “day.”) Which day differs from Hindi’s version, and how? (**Sunday** — Kannada’s *Bhānuvāra* (“light”) uses a different Sanskrit sun-name than Hindi’s *Ravivār* (“Ravi”).)

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

By the end of this chapter: I can name four basic colours in Kannada — black, white, red, and blue.

Say ಕಪ್ಪು, ಬಿಳಿ, ಕೆಂಪು — the three native colours — then the borrowed ನೀಲಿ, and point out that the week is Sanskritic where the colours are not.

11.1 ಕಪ್ಪು, ಬಿಳಿ, ಕೆಂಪು, ನೀಲಿ — native colors, after a fully Sanskrit week

Kannada’s week ran entirely on Sanskrit deity-names. Its colors tell a different story — here, native Dravidian vocabulary is back in charge, except for one familiar exception.

You’ll want to know: Three native colors

- ಕಪ್ಪು (*kappu*) = “**black**” — native Dravidian.
- ಬಿಳಿ (*bili*) = “**white**” — native Dravidian.
- ಕೆಂಪು (*kempu*) = “**red**” — native Dravidian.

You’ll want to know: The familiar borrowed blue

ನೀಲಿ (*nīli*) = “**blue**” — from the **same Sanskrit ನೀल** (*nīla*) that Tamil, Malayalam, and Hindi all reach for. Even Kannada, whose week went fully Sanskritic, still keeps its everyday black/white/red **native** — it’s specifically **blue** that pulls in the Sanskrit word, across all four Dravidian languages and Hindi alike.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kappu, bili, kempu” — black, white, red
- “nīli” — blue, the shared Sanskrit word
- the contrast — Kannada’s week is Sanskritic, but its colors (except blue) are native

Before you move on

Are Kannada’s black/white/red native or Sanskrit? (**Native Dravidian** — kappu, bili, kempu.) Which color is the shared Sanskrit loan across Kannada, Tamil, Malayalam, and Hindi? (**Blue** — ನೀಲಿ *nīli* / நீலம் *nīlam* / नील *nīla* / नीला *nīlā*.)

Chapter 12

Family

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my brothers and sisters in Kannada, choosing the right word for older or younger.

Name ಅಪ್ಪ and ಅಮ್ಮ, then the four age-graded siblings ಅಣ್ಣ · ತಮ್ಮ · ಅಕ್ಕ · ತಂಗಿ, where age is chosen before gender.

12.1 ಅಪ್ಪ, ಅಮ್ಮ, and four sibling words — the same system as Tamil

Kannada asks the same question Tamil does about any sibling: **older, or younger?** — and the words for answering it are almost identical.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- ಅಪ್ಪ (*appa*) = “**father**” — matches Tamil *appā* closely.
- ಅಮ್ಮ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches Tamil *ammā* closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kannada	meaning	compare Tamil
ಅಣ್ಣ (<i>aṇṇa</i>)	older brother	<i>aṇṇan</i> — near match
ತಮ್ಮ (<i>tamma</i>)	younger brother	<i>tambi</i> — near match
ಅಕ್ಕ (<i>akka</i>)	older sister	<i>akkā</i> — near match
ತಂಗಿ (<i>tangi</i>)	younger sister	<i>tangai</i> — near match

Just like Tamil, Kannada has **no single word** that simply means “brother” or “sister” — you name the sibling’s **relative age** every time,

not just their gender. This age-first system runs across the whole Dravidian family, not just one language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “appa, amma” — father, mother
- “appa, tamma” — older/younger brother
- “akka, tangi” — older/younger sister

Before you move on

How many Kannada sibling words are there, and what do they split on? (**Four** — ಅಣ್ಣ/ತಮ್ಮ, ಅಕ್ಕ/ತಂಗಿ — split by **relative age**, not just gender.) How closely do Kannada’s words match Tamil’s? (**Very closely** — nearly the same forms across the whole set.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Kannada.

Say ತಲೆ and ಕೈ, and hear how nearly unchanged they are across Tamil, Malayalam and Kannada.

13.1 ತಲೆ, ಕೈ — head and hand, the shared Dravidian core

Three languages, nearly one word each — Kannada’s basic body parts line up with Tamil and Malayalam almost perfectly.

You’ll want to know: The words

- ತಲೆ (*tale*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian, matching Tamil *talai* and Malayalam *thala*.
- ಕೈ (*kai*) = “**hand**” — native Dravidian, matching Tamil and Malayalam’s *kai* almost exactly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tale” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the match — nearly identical across Tamil, Malayalam, Kannada

Before you move on

What are Kannada's words for head and hand? (ತಲೆ tale, ಕೈ kai.)
How closely do they match Tamil and Malayalam? (**Very closely** —
all three share essentially the same native Dravidian words.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Kannada, including the monsoon that actually shapes the Karnataka year.

Say ಬೇಸಿಗೆ, ಮಳೆಗಾಲ and ಚಳಿಗಾಲ from native roots, then the doubly-Sanskrit ವಸಂತ ಋತು for spring.

14.1 ವಸಂತ ಋತು, ಬೇಸಿಗೆ, ಮಳೆಗಾಲ, ಚಳಿಗಾಲ — native words, plus a double Sanskrit loan

Kannada’s summer, rain, and cold words are native, just like Tamil’s — but its word for “spring” borrows **twice** from Sanskrit, not once.

You’ll want to know: The words

Kannada	meaning	source
ವಸಂತ ಋತು (<i>vasanta rtu</i>)	“spring”	both <i>vasanta</i> AND ಋತು <i>rtu</i> (“season”) are Sanskrit
ಬೇಸಿಗೆ (<i>bēsige</i>)	“summer”	native Dravidian
ಮಳೆಗಾಲ (<i>maḷegāla</i>)	“rainy season”	ಮಳೆ <i>maḷe</i> , native Dravidian (“rain”) + ಕಾಲ <i>kāla</i> (“time,” itself a Sanskrit loan)
ಚಳಿಗಾಲ (<i>caligāla</i>)	“winter/cold season”	ಚಳಿ <i>cali</i> , native Dravidian (“cold”) + <i>kāla</i>

Why it's said this way

Where Tamil and Malayalam just say *kaalam* (“time/season,” itself ultimately Sanskrit-derived too, but assimilated long ago as ordinary vocabulary), Kannada’s word for spring, **ವಸಂತ ಋತು**, keeps **both** halves visibly Sanskrit — *vasanta* the season-name, *ṛtu* the very word for “season.” Summer, rain, and cold, by contrast, are built on native Dravidian roots (*bēsige*, *maḷe*, *caḷi*).

And as with Tamil and Malayalam: it’s **ಮಳೆಗಾಲ** (*maḷegāla*, the rains) that shapes Karnataka’s agricultural year the most, not a clean four-way Western split.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bēsige” — summer, native
- “maḷegāla” — the rains
- “caḷigāla” — the cold season, native
- the double loan — “vasanta ṛtu” — both halves Sanskrit

Before you move on

How does **ವಸಂತ ಋತು** differ from the Tamil/Malayalam spring-word? (**Both halves are Sanskrit** — *vasanta* and *ṛtu*, “season” itself — where Tamil/Malayalam just add the long-assimilated *kaalam*.) Which season actually shapes Karnataka’s year most? (**ಮಳೆಗಾಲ**, the rains.)

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water in Kannada and tell raw rice apart from cooked rice.

Say ನೀರು — matching Tamil’s neer, not Malayalam’s — then separate ಅಕ್ಕಿ, raw rice, from ಅನ್ನ, the cooked rice on the plate.

15.1 ನೀರು, ಅಕ್ಕಿ, ಅನ್ನ — water matching Tamil, and rice, raw and cooked

Kannada’s water-word sides with Tamil, not with Malayalam’s surprising break from the pack.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನೀರು (*nīru*) = “**water**” — matching Tamil’s நீர் (*nīr*, the root inside *taṇṇīr*) closely. Kannada didn’t make Malayalam’s switch to the *vel-* “bright/white” root.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- ಅಕ್ಕಿ (*akki*) = “**rice**” (raw grain).
- ಅನ್ನ (*anna*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — likely Sanskrit-influenced, the same general idea as Tamil’s *sātam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nīru” — water, matching Tamil
- “akki” — raw rice
- “anna” — cooked rice

Before you move on

Does Kannada’s water-word match Tamil’s or Malayalam’s? (**Tamil’s** — *nīru/nīr*, not Malayalam’s *vellam*.) What’s the raw/cooked rice pair? (ಅಕ್ಕಿ *akki* raw, ಅನ್ನ *anna* cooked.)

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve traditional Kannada months and say when the new year Ugadi falls.

Recite Caitra through Phālguna, place Ugadi at Chaitra Śukla Pratipada, and note that this calendar is shared with Hindi, not with Tamil or Malayalam.

16.1 ಚೈತ್ರ to ಫಾಲ್ಗುಣ — the calendar Kannada shares with Hindi, not with Tamil

Tamil and Malayalam each built their own solar calendar. Kannada takes a different path entirely — the same path as Hindi.

You'll want to know: The twelve months

ಚೈತ್ರ, ವೈಶಾಖ, ಜ್ಯೇಷ್ಠ, ಆಷಾಢ, ಶ್ರಾವಣ, ಭಾದ್ರಪದ, ಆಶ್ವಯುಜ, ಕಾರ್ತಿಕ, ಮಾರ್ಗಶಿರ, ಪುಷ್ಯ, ಮಾಘ, ಫಾಲ್ಗುಣ (*Caitra, Vaiśākha, Jyēṣṭha, Āṣāḍha, Śrāvaṇa, Bhādrapada, Āśvayuja, Kārtika, Mārgaśīra, Puṣya, Māgha, Phālguna*).

Why it's said this way

This is the **same pan-Indian Sanskritic lunisolar calendar** you already met as Hindi's **Vikram Samvat** — the same twelve month names, tied to the same **six-ṛtu** seasonal cycle. Karnataka's own New Year, **Ugadi**, falls on *Chaitra Śukla Pratipada* — the first day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra — exactly the reasoning behind Hindu New Year celebrations across much of India. Unlike Tamil's or Malayalam's genuinely home-grown solar calendars, Kannada didn't build its own

separate system here — it shares this one with Hindi, Telugu, and much of the rest of the subcontinent.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Caitra, Vaiśākha, Jyēṣṭha, Āṣāḍha, Śrāvaṇa, Bhādrapada, Āśvayuja, Kārtika, Mārgaśira, Puṣya, Māgha, Phālguna”
- “Ugadi — Chaitra Śukla Pratipada”
- the honest point — shared with Hindi, unlike Tamil/Malayalam’s own calendars

Before you move on

Does Kannada use its own solar calendar, like Tamil and Malayalam? (**No** — it uses the **same pan-Indian lunisolar calendar** as Hindi’s Vikram Samvat.) What is Kannada’s New Year called, and when does it fall? (**Ugadi**, on *Chaitra Śukla Pratipada*.)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Kannada and point out the “middle” word they share.

Say ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ and ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ, then isolate the madhya sitting inside both.

17.1 ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ, ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ — one Sanskrit root, two everyday Kannada words

You’ve just seen Hindi’s *dopahar* (an old timekeeping unit) and *aadhi raat* (plain “half night”). Kannada takes a completely different path — straight to Sanskrit, and straight down the middle.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (*madhyāhna*) = “**noon, midday**” — a Sanskrit *tatsama* (borrowed whole, unchanged) compound: ಮಧ್ಯ (*madhya*, “**middle**”) + ಅಹ್ನ (*ahna*, “**day**”). This is the everyday, ordinary Kannada word for noon — not a formal or bookish alternative the way it can feel in some of its sister languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ (*madhyarātri*) = “**midnight**” — the exact same ಮಧ್ಯ (*madhya*, “**middle**”) root, this time compounded with ರಾತ್ರಿ (*rātri*, “**night**”). Same logic, same “middle” word, just paired with “night” instead of “day.”

Why it's said this way

Both words are unmistakably **Sanskrit tatsama** compounds — Kannada borrowed them whole rather than building native Dravidian equivalents. That's worth contrasting directly with Hindi, a language actually *descended* from Sanskrit: Hindi has these exact same words too (*madhyāhna*, *madhyarātri*), but treats them as the more **formal, literary** register — its everyday words are the homegrown *dopahar* (“two pahars”) and *aadhi raat* (“half night”) instead. Kannada, by contrast, took the Sanskrit-formal compound and made it the **plain, everyday** word — there's no separate native-Dravidian doublet in common use here the way there is for some other concepts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “madhyāhna” — noon, “middle of the day”
- “madhyarātri” — midnight, “middle of the night”
- the shared piece — “madhya,” middle, in both words

Before you move on

What Sanskrit root do ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ and ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ share, and what does it mean? (ಮಧ್ಯ, *madhya*, “middle.”) Are these native Dravidian words or Sanskrit borrowings? (**Sanskrit tatsama** borrowings, taken whole.) Does Hindi treat its version of these words as everyday or formal? (**Formal/literary** — Hindi's everyday words are *dopahar* and *aadhi raat* instead.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone the time on the hour in Kannada.

Say ಗಂಟೆ — *hour*, and also “bell” — then ಒಂದು ಗಂಟೆ and ಎರಡು ಗಂಟೆ for one and two o’clock.

18.1 ಗಂಟೆ — the same “bell” word as Hindi, borrowed through Prakrit

You’ve already met Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* — “hour,” literally “bell.” Kannada has the exact same word, arriving by the exact same logic.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಗಂಟೆ (*gaṇṭe*) = “**hour**” — and, just like Hindi, it means “**bell, gong**” just as commonly. It’s related to the same Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*, “bell”). The semantic shift is identical to Hindi’s: temples, towns, and clock towers announced the hour by striking a bell, so the bell-word became the hour-word.

Why it’s said this way

This is a genuinely different picture from what you’ll see in Tamil. Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, like Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā*, is a **Sanskrit-derived** “bell → hour” word. Tamil, by contrast, most likely uses a **native Dravidian** word for exactly the same “bell → hour” idea — a different root entirely, arrived at independently (though even specialists don’t call this fully settled).

So the *pattern* (bell-word becomes hour-word) repeats across languages, but the *word itself* splits along the same Sanskrit/native line you’ve seen before in this course (compare *madhyāhna* vs. Tamil’s *naḷ*-based words for noon).

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ಒಂದು ಗಂಟೆ. — “One o’clock.” (*ondu gaṇṭe*, “one hour/bell”)

ಎರಡು ಗಂಟೆ. — “Two o’clock.” (*eraḍu gaṇṭe*)

Kannada simply pairs the cardinal number with *gaṇṭe* — no ordinal/cardinal split like Arabic’s, no singular/plural verb switch like Hindi’s *bajnā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gaṇṭe” — hour, also “bell”
- “ondu gaṇṭe” — one o’clock
- “eraḍu gaṇṭe” — two o’clock

Before you move on

What does ಗಂಟೆ mean besides “hour,” and what Sanskrit word is it related to? (“**Bell, gong**” — related to Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā*.) Is this the same root Hindi uses for “hour”? (**Yes** — Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* is the same Sanskrit word.) Does Tamil use this same Sanskrit root for “hour”? (**Most likely not** — it uses a native Dravidian word instead, arrived at independently.)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone how old they are in Kannada and give my own age in return.

Ask ನಿನ್ನ ವಯಸ್ಸು ಎಷ್ಟು? and answer ನನ್ನ ವಯಸ್ಸು ಇಪ್ಪತ್ತು — a complete verbless exchange about age.

19.1 ನಿನ್ನ ವಯಸ್ಸು ಎಷ್ಟು? — “your age, how much?”

Here's a genuinely nice callback: the Sanskrit word behind Kannada's “age” is a distant cousin of a Latin word you already know.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ವಯಸ್ಸು (*vayassu*, “age”) comes from Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, youth, vigor, strength”), which traces back to **Proto-Indo-European** *wéyh₁os*. That PIE root is the **same** one behind Latin *vīs*, “force, strength, vigor” — so Sanskrit's word for “age” and Latin's word for “force” are genuine, distant cousins, both carrying the older sense of “vigor, life-force” before splitting toward different specific meanings.

Grammar Lens: a simple possessive, no verb

ನಿನ್ನ ವಯಸ್ಸು ಎಷ್ಟು? — “How old are you?” — literally “**your** age — **how much**?” (*ninna vayassu eṣṭu?*)

ನನ್ನ ವಯಸ್ಸು ಇಪ್ಪತ್ತು. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my** age [is] **twenty**.” (*nanna vayassu ippattu.*)

Just like Arabic's *ʿumr*, this is a **verbless** construction in the present

tense — Kannada simply states “your age” and “how much,” with no “is” needed. But notice the shape is simpler than Arabic’s: no possessive suffix fused onto the noun, just the ordinary possessive word ನಿನ್ನ (*ninna*, “your”) sitting in front of ವಯಸ್ಸು.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vayassu” — age
- “ninna vayassu eṣṭu?” — how old are you?
- “nanna vayassu ippattu” — I am twenty, “my age [is] twenty”

Before you move on

What Sanskrit word is ವಯಸ್ಸು from, and what Latin word is its PIE cousin? (वयस्, *vayas*, “age/vigor” — cousin of Latin *vīs*, “force,” both from PIE *wéyh₁os*.) Does Kannada use a verb to state age? (**No** — “your age how-much,” no verb needed.) How do you say “I am twenty”? (Nanna vayassu ippattu — “my age [is] twenty.”)

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the weather is doing in Kannada and count past ten up to twenty.

Say ಹವಾಮಾನ — the Persian *hava* plus Sanskrit *māna* — and report the weather with ಮಳೆ ಬರುತ್ತಿದೆ, “rain is coming.”

20.1 ಹನ್ನೊಂದು to ಇಪ್ಪತ್ತು — numbers 11–20

You’ve now seen four different language families each build “twenty” as its own special, opaque word — Sanskrit’s *vimshati*, Latin’s *viginti*, Arabic’s *‘ishrūn*. Kannada’s twenty genuinely started life as “two tens” too — but be careful: the modern surface no longer shows it plainly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kannada’s teens are built on ಹತ್ತು (*hattu*, “ten”) plus each digit — ಹನ್ನೊಂದು (*hannondu*, 11), ಹನ್ನೆರಡು (*hanneradu*, 12), and onward through ಹತ್ತೊಂಬತ್ತು (*hattombattu*, 19). Each teen is a compound built the same way English builds “four-teen” — just placed the same digit-plus-ten pattern in front instead of behind.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಇಪ್ಪತ್ತು (*ippattu*, “twenty”) traces back to Proto-Dravidian ***ir-** (“two”) + ***paHtu** (“ten”) — a genuine compositional origin, “two-tens.” But be honest about what’s actually visible today: the ***ir-** piece is an old *bound* root, not the same as modern Kannada’s everyday word for “two,” ಎರಡು (*eradu*) — a separate, longer descendant of the same ancient

family. And the “ten” piece surfaces here as **-pp-** (geminated after the *r*), not as modern ಹತ್ತು (*hattu*)’s **h-** — because Kannada’s historical *p* → *h* shift only fired at the **start** of a word, and this “ten” sits in the **middle** of the compound, so it never lenited. So *ippattu* really did start as “two-tens” — you just can’t spot modern *eraḍu* or modern *hattu* inside it anymore the way you might expect. Compare this to Sanskrit’s *विंशति* (*vimshati*), Latin’s *vīgintī*, and Arabic’s *عشرون* (*‘ishrūn*): those have **no** compositional “two-ten” origin at all, not even a buried one — a genuinely different kind of history from Kannada’s.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hannondu, hannerāḍu” — 11, 12
- “hattu” — ten (today’s word), “eraḍu” — two (today’s word)
- “ippattu” — twenty, “two-tens” underneath, from the OLD *ir-/paHtu* roots, not directly from *hattu/eraḍu*

Before you move on

How are Kannada’s teens built? (ಹತ್ತು (ten) + a digit, compounded.) Does ಇಪ್ಪತ್ತು (twenty) have a compositional “two-tens” origin? (**Yes** — Proto-Dravidian **ir-* “two” + **paHtu* “ten.”) Can you still spot modern *eraḍu* or modern *hattu* inside it today? (**No** — the old bound “two” root and the un-lenited middle-of-word “ten” root look different from their modern standalone descendants.) Do Sanskrit’s *vimshati* or Latin’s *vīgintī* have any compositional origin like this at all? (**No** — neither has a buried “two-ten” history the way Kannada’s does.)

20.2 ಹವಾಮಾನ — a genuine two-language hybrid word

Kannada’s word for “weather” isn’t purely Sanskrit or purely native — it’s a compound with a piece from each of two different borrowed sources.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹವಾಮಾನ (*havāmāna*) = “**weather**” — built from two pieces:

- ಹವಾ (*hava*, “**air**”) — itself a loanword, from **Persian** هوا (*havā*), which traces back to **Arabic** هَوَاً (*hawāʾ*, “air”). This is the exact same root behind Hindi’s own हवा (*havā*, “air, wind”).
- ಮಾನ (*māna*, “**measure**”) — from **Sanskrit** मान (*māna*), “measure, standard” (the same word behind *pramāṇa*, “proof, measure of truth”).

So *havāmāna* literally means “**air-measure**” — and it’s genuinely a two-source hybrid, not a single borrowed compound: one piece Perso-Arabic, one piece Sanskrit, fused into one Kannada word.

You’ll want to know: ಮಳೆ ಬರುತ್ತಿದೆ — “rain is coming”

ಮಳೆ ಬರುತ್ತಿದೆ. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is coming**.”
(*maḷe baruttide*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “havāmāna” — weather, literally “air-measure”
- “hava” — air, a Persian/Arabic loan
- “maḷe baruttide” — it’s raining, “rain is coming”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of ಹವಾಮಾನ, and where does each come from? (ಹವಾ, “air,” a **Persian/Arabic** loan; ಮಾನ, “measure,” native **Sanskrit**.) What does *havāmāna* literally mean? (“**Air-measure**.”) What other Indian language shares the exact same word for “air”? (**Hindi** — *havā*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Kannada.

Say ನಾಯಿ, an unambiguously native Dravidian root, and ಬೆಕ್ಕು, a different ancient root from Tamil’s everyday cat word.

21.1 ನಾಯಿ, ಬೆಕ್ಕು — solid ground, and a genuine split

After a whole arc of mystery dog-words — Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, Hindi’s *kuttā* — here’s the opposite: a dog-word with absolutely no mystery attached.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*, “dog”) is a genuine, native **Proto-Dravidian** root — no debate, no substrate mystery, nothing like the *perro/dog/kuttā* pattern you’ve now seen across three unrelated language families. It’s the same root shared right across the Dravidian family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*, “cat”) is where things get honestly more complicated. It’s cognate with a **different** ancient Dravidian root — the same one behind Tamil and Malayalam’s word for “**wildcat**” or “**civet cat**” — not the same root as Tamil’s **everyday** word for cat. So unlike “dog,” where Dravidian largely agrees on one shared root, “cat” genuinely **splits**: different Dravidian languages settled on different ancient roots for their everyday word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāyi” — dog, solid native Dravidian, no mystery
- “bekku” — cat, a different Dravidian root than Tamil’s everyday word

Before you move on

Is நாயி a mystery word, like Spanish’s *perro* or Hindi’s *kuttā*? (**No** — a solid, native Proto-Dravidian root.) Does ಬೆಕ್ಕು come from the same root as Tamil’s everyday cat-word? (**No** — a genuinely different ancient Dravidian root, related instead to the word for “wildcat.”)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Kannada, on top of the four colours I already had.

Say ಹಸಿರು, a true cousin of Tamil paccai and Telugu pacca, then ಹಳದಿ, the turmeric-borrowing that is secretly a cousin of German gelb.

22.1 ಹಸಿರು, ಹಳದಿ — a real Dravidian family, and a borrowed cousin of gelb

Kannada’s green word belongs to a real Dravidian family you’ll meet again soon. Its yellow word isn’t native at all — and it turns out to be hiding the very same ancient root this whole arc keeps circling back to.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹಸಿರು (hasiru, “green”) comes from Old Kannada ಪಸಿರ್ (pasir), from Proto-Dravidian *pac-, “green” — the exact same root behind Tamil’s பச்சை (paccai) and Telugu’s పచ్చ (pacca). Kannada even keeps a doublet of its own, ಪಚ್ಚಿ (pacce), sitting right alongside hasiru. So unlike Kannada’s blue (ನೀಲಿ, borrowed from Sanskrit), green here is the real, deep, native Dravidian word — and this particular root will keep resurfacing as Telugu, Malayalam, and Tamil’s own green words come up later in this same arc.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹಳದಿ (*haḷadi*, “yellow”) is **not** Kannada’s native turmeric word — that’s ಅರಿಶಿನ (*ariśina*). Instead, *haḷadi* appears to be shaped by Sanskrit/Hindi हरिद्रा/हल्दी (*haridrā/haldī*, “turmeric”), the same word that gives “turmeric” across a huge swath of Indo-Aryan languages (Hindi/Urdu/Punjabi *haldi*, Bengali *holud*, Odia *haladi*) — and in some of these, like Bengali and Odia, that turmeric-word doubles as the everyday word for the color **yellow** itself, exactly as *haḷadi* does in Kannada (Hindi keeps the two separate: *haldī* stays “turmeric,” while “yellow” is the unrelated word *pīlā*). Here’s the part that closes a loop running through this whole arc: *haridrā* itself traces back to हरि (*hari*, “yellow, tawny”), from **Proto-Indo-European** **ǵʰelh₃-* — the **same ancient root** already behind Hindi’s own हरा (*harā*, “green”) and German’s *gelb* (“yellow”). So Kannada picked up its yellow word from a completely different language family, Indo-Aryan rather than Dravidian — and that borrowed word still lands on the exact same PIE root this arc has been tracing all along.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ಹಸಿರು” — green, a real Dravidian cousin of Tamil *pacca* and Telugu *pacca*
- “ಹಳದಿ” — yellow, borrowed, and secretly a cousin of *gelb*
- the contrast — *hasiru* is native Dravidian; *haḷadi* is a Sanskrit/ Hindi loan built on the turmeric word

Before you move on

What Proto-Dravidian root gives ಹಸಿರು (*hasiru*), and which two other Dravidian languages share it? (**pac-*, “green” — shared with **Tamil’s** *pacca* and **Telugu’s** *pacca*.) Is ಹಳದಿ (*haḷadi*) Kannada’s native word for turmeric? (**No** — that’s *ariśina*; *haḷadi* is a Sanskrit/Hindi loan.) What ancient PIE root connects **haḷadi**, through Sanskrit **hari**, to Hindi’s *harā* and German’s *gelb*? (**ǵʰelh₃-*, “to shine.”)

Chapter 23

Day

By the end of this chapter: I can say “day” in Kannada and tell it apart from the native word for daytime.

Say ದಿನ, kept whole as a Sanskrit tatsama where Hindi’s din eroded, and set it against native ಹಗಲು, which means daytime rather than a day.

23.1 ದಿನ (dina) — “day,” Sanskrit kept whole

You’ve already met Sanskrit’s “middle” compounds for noon and midnight. Here’s the plain word for “day” itself — and a genuinely interesting twist on how borrowing works.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ದಿನ (dina) — “day” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama** word: borrowed **whole**, unchanged, the same way *madhyāhna*/*madhyarātri* were (Chapter 17). It’s Kannada’s ordinary, everyday word for “a day.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the honest twist: Kannada’s *dina* and Hindi’s दिन (*din*) trace to the **exact same** Sanskrit word, दिन (*dina*) — but they got there by **different routes**. Hindi’s *din* is a **tadbhava** form: Sanskrit *dina* wore down naturally over centuries, through Prakrit, losing its final vowel along the way. Kannada’s *dina*, by contrast, is a direct **tatsama** borrowing — taken straight from Sanskrit, unworn, keeping the full shape. So Kannada’s *dina* and Hindi’s *din* look almost identical, but one is an unbroken **inheritance** (eroded), the other a **later borrowing**

(kept whole) — genuinely different histories landing on nearly the same modern word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kannada does have a genuine **native Dravidian** word here too: ಹಗಲು (*hagalu*) — but be careful, it means specifically “**daytime**” (the daylight hours, as opposed to night), not “**a day**” as a calendar unit. It’s not a synonym for *dina*; it’s a different sense of “day” entirely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dina” — “day,” Sanskrit tatsama, kept whole
- the twist — dina and Hindi’s din, same Sanskrit source, but borrowing vs. natural erosion
- hagalu — native Dravidian, “daytime,” a different sense than dina

Before you move on

Is Kannada’s ದಿನ a tatsama borrowing or a tadbhava inheritance? (**Tatsama** — borrowed whole from Sanskrit.) How does this differ from Hindi’s दिन (*din*), even though both trace to the same Sanskrit word? (**Din is tadbhava** — naturally eroded through Prakrit — while Kannada’s *dina* was borrowed later, unworn.) What does ಹಗಲು (*hagalu*) mean, and is it a synonym for *dina*? (“**Daytime**” — a different sense, not “a day” as a calendar unit.)

Chapter 24

Night

By the end of this chapter: I can say “night” in Kannada and recognise it inside the midnight word I already knew.

Say ರಾತ್ರಿ, find it again inside ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ, and note that native ಇರುಳು lost its job where ಹಗಲು kept a different one.

24.1 ರಾತ್ರಿ (rātri) — “night,” and its native cousin, pushed aside

Last lesson’s *dina* had a living native partner, *hagalu*. This word’s native partner tells a different, more honest story — one of being pushed out, not living alongside.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ರಾತ್ರಿ (rātri) — “night” — is the same Sanskrit **tatsama** word already hiding inside ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ (*madhyarātri*, “midnight,” Chapter 17), now standing on its own as Kannada’s ordinary, everyday word for “night.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kannada **does** have a genuine **native Dravidian** word for night: ಇರುಳು (*iruḷu*), from **Proto-Dravidian** **cirVl* — a real pan-Dravidian cognate, matching **Tamil**’s இருள் (*irul*), **Malayalam**’s ഇരുൾ (*irul*), and **Telugu**’s ఇరులు (*irulu*). But here’s the honest difference from last lesson’s *hagalu*: while *hagalu* is still a **living, everyday** word (just for a different sense, “daytime”), *iruḷu* has been genuinely **pushed aside** by the Sanskrit loan — it now survives mainly in **older poetry**, carrying

extra metaphorical weight (“darkness,” even “ignorance”), rather than in everyday speech. *Rātri* simply **won** the job of “night” in modern Kannada.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rātri” — “night,” already met inside madhyarātri
- “irulu” — the real native word, now mostly archaic/poetic
- the honest contrast — *hagalu* still lives (different sense); *irulu* was pushed aside (same sense, lost the job)

Before you move on

Where have you already met ರಾತ್ರಿ before this lesson? (ಮಧ್ಯರಾತ್ರಿ, *madhyarātri*, “midnight.”) What genuine native Dravidian word for “night” does Kannada have, and what’s its status today? (ಇರುಳು, *irulu* — largely **archaic**, surviving mainly in older poetry.) How is *irulu*’s story different from *hagalu*’s, from last lesson? (**Hagalu still lives**, for a different sense [“daytime”]; **irulu was pushed aside** entirely by the Sanskrit loan, for the same sense [“night”].)

Chapter 25

Good Night

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Kannada.

Say ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ — “auspicious night” — pairing the ರಾತ್ರಿ already learned with śubha, from a root meaning “to be beautiful.”

25.1 ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ (śubha rātri) — “good night,” auspicious to the end

You already have *rātri*. Pair it with one more Sanskrit word, and you have Kannada’s everyday “good night” — the same phrase, word for word, as Hindi’s.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ (śubha rātri) — “good night” — literally “**auspicious night**.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: ರಾತ್ರಿ (*rātri*, “night,” already met last lesson) plus ಶುಭ (*śubha*, “auspicious, good”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಶುಭ (śubha) comes from the Sanskrit verbal root śubh, whose core sense is “**to be beautiful, splendid**” — traceable to a well-sourced **Proto-Indo-European** root, **kewb^h*- (“to be beautiful”). A further, more speculative connection to a root meaning “to shine” has also been proposed — but either way, the underlying idea is a familiar one: **auspiciousness imagined as a kind of radiance or beauty**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the honest cross-language note: ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ and Hindi’s own शुभ रात्रि are, word for word, the **exact same phrase** — a Dravidian language and an Indo-Aryan language landing on an identical “good night.” The most likely explanation is **shared Sanskrit vocabulary**, not one language directly copying the phrase from the other — but be honest about the limits of that claim: “good night” as a farewell greeting is itself a **modern** convention across Indian languages, not an ancient one, so some degree of cross-language reinforcement (Hindi’s wide reach as a pan-Indian media language, for instance) can’t be ruled out either. Unlike Hindi, where *rātri* is the formal member of a live doublet against everyday *raat*, Kannada’s *rātri* is simply the ordinary word (Chapter 24) — so this phrase draws on shared **Sanskrit vocabulary**, not a shared “formal-versus-everyday” register split the way it does in Hindi.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious”
- the honest cross-language note — identical to Hindi’s shubh rātri, most likely via shared Sanskrit vocabulary, though direct reinforcement can’t be fully ruled out

Before you move on

What does ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) What does ಶುಭ literally trace back to? (A root meaning “**to be beautiful, splendid.**”) Is Kannada’s *śubha rātri* definitely borrowed directly from Hindi? (**Most likely not** — shared Sanskrit vocabulary is the more parsimonious explanation, though since “good night” as a farewell is itself a modern convention, some cross-language reinforcement can’t be fully ruled out.)

Chapter 26

Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can say “morning” in Kannada using the language’s own native word for it.

Say ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ, trace it to beḷagu (“to dawn”) and beḷaku (“light”), and contrast it with the Sanskrit dina, rātri and madhyāhna around it.

26.1 ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (beḷagge) — the one time-word that’s genuinely Kannada’s own

Every everyday time-word you’ve met in Kannada so far — day, night, noon, midnight — has been Sanskrit, borrowed whole. This one breaks that pattern completely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (beḷagge) — “morning” — is **native Dravidian**, built on ಬೆಳಗು (beḷagu, “to shine, to become bright, to dawn”) and the related noun ಬೆಳಕು (beḷaku, “light”). Morning is, quite literally, “the shining,” “the dawning” — a transparent, homegrown metaphor, no borrowed vocabulary anywhere in it.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s what makes this lesson different from every other Kannada time-word lesson so far: ದಿನ (dina, “day”), ರಾತ್ರಿ (rātri, “night”), and ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (madhyāhna, “noon”) are all genuine **Sanskrit tatsama** borrowings, taken whole, doing the plain everyday job in Kannada. ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ breaks that streak — it’s the one everyday time-word in this set that’s actually

Kannada’s own, not a loan from anywhere. If you’d only met *dina*, *ratri*, and *madhyāhna*, you might start to assume every Kannada time-word is Sanskrit underneath. This one is the honest counter-example — though, matching the pattern already seen with *hagalu* and *irulu* (Chapters 23–24), a native compound for “noon” does technically exist too: **ನಡುಹಗಲು** (*naḍuhagalu*, “middle-of-daytime,” built from *naḍu*, “middle,” the same everyday word already met, plus *hagalu*). It just lost the everyday job to *madhyāhna*, the same way *hagalu* and *irulu* were pushed into narrower, or archaic, roles by their own Sanskrit competitors.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “beḷagge” — “morning,” native Dravidian
- the root — beḷagu, “to shine, to dawn,” and beḷaku, “light”
- the contrast — *dina*, *ratri*, *madhyāhna* are all Sanskrit; beḷagge is genuinely Kannada’s own

Before you move on

What native root does ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ come from, and what does it mean? (ಬೆಳಗು/ಬೆಳಕು — “to shine/dawn” and “light.”) Is ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ a Sanskrit tatsama, like *dina*, *ratri*, and *madhyāhna*? (**No** — genuinely native Dravidian, the odd one out among Kannada’s everyday time-words.)

Chapter 27

Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can say “evening” in Kannada.

Say ಸಂಜೆ, follow it back through Maharashtri Prakrit to Sanskrit *saṃdhyā*, and set it beside Hindi’s साँझ, the same root down a different Prakrit road.

27.1 ಸಂಜೆ (sañje) — a Sanskrit word that arrived already worn down

ದಿನ, ರಾತ್ರಿ, and ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ all arrived in Kannada whole, unworn, straight from Sanskrit. This word took a very different route — and it lands somewhere genuinely surprising.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಸಂಜೆ (sañje) — “evening” — traces to **Sanskrit** ಸಂಧ್ಯಾ (*saṃdhyā*, “twilight,” literally “the junction of day and night”) — but it didn’t arrive in Kannada as a fresh, whole tatsama the way *dina*, *ratri*, and *madhyāhna* did. Instead, it came by way of **Maharashtri Prakrit** ಸಂಝಾ (*sañjhā*) — Sanskrit’s word, already worn down by centuries of everyday Middle Indo-Aryan speech, *then* borrowed into Kannada in that already-eroded shape.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the genuinely surprising part: Hindi’s own evening word, साँझ (*sañjh*), comes from the **exact same** Sanskrit ಸಂಧ್ಯಾ — but by a **different** route. Hindi *inherited* it, generation to generation, through

Śauraseni Prakrit (a different, sister Middle Indo-Aryan dialect than the Maharashtri Prakrit Kannada borrowed from). Two separate erosion paths — one an unbroken inheritance within the Indo-Aryan family, one a loan crossing into a completely different language family — and they land on nearly **identical-sounding** modern words, *sañje* and *sāñjh*, purely because they share the same Sanskrit starting point.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sañje” — “evening,” from Sanskrit *sandhyā* via Maharashtri Prakrit
- the contrast with *dina*/*ratri*/*madhyāhna* — those arrived whole; *sañje* arrived already worn down
- the striking convergence — Hindi’s साँझ, same Sanskrit root, different Prakrit path, nearly the same sound today

Before you move on

Does ಸಂಜೆ arrive in Kannada as a fresh, whole Sanskrit tatsama, like *dina* and *ratri* did? (**No** — it arrived already worn down, via Maharashtri Prakrit ಸಂಝಾ.) What Hindi word shares ಸಂಜೆ’s exact Sanskrit root, and by what different path did it get there? (साँझ (*sāñjh*) — inherited via a different sister Prakrit, Śauraseni, rather than borrowed via Maharashtri.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can say “afternoon” in Kannada and keep it distinct from noon.

Say ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ, split it into *apara* (“latter”) + *ahna* (“day”), and match that -ahna against the one in ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ.

28.1 ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (aparāhna) — the same “-ahna” pattern, a different first piece

You already know ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ, “noon” — “middle” plus “day.” This lesson’s word for “afternoon” uses the exact same building pattern, just with a different first piece.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (aparāhna) — “afternoon” — is a genuine **Sanskrit tatsama**: ಅಪರ (apara, “latter, further”) + the same -ಅಹ್ನ (-ahna, “day”) suffix already hiding inside ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (madhyāhna, “noon,” Chapter 17). Same clean two-piece structure, same “day” ending — just swap *madhya* (“middle”) for *apara* (“latter, further along”) and you move from “noon” to “afternoon.” This distinction comes from a genuine, classical **five-part Sanskrit division of the day** — *prāta* (early morning), *saṅgava*, *madhyāhna* (noon), *aparāhna* (afternoon), *sāyāhna* (evening) — with *aparāhna* landing specifically as the fourth part, after noon and before evening.

Why it's said this way

Here's where this lesson needs real care: some sources describe ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ itself being stretched loosely in casual modern speech to cover the whole afternoon too — which would echo Hindi's own दोपहर, already found in this course to have genuinely widened from “precisely noon” to “the whole afternoon.” But the evidence for Kannada is **much thinner** than what backed the Hindi finding — general dictionary listings rather than clear, independently-confirmed usage sources. Treat this as a plausible, hedged parallel, not a settled fact the way दोपहर's widening was. ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ remains the more precisely, formally correct word for “afternoon” specifically.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aparāhna” — “afternoon,” apara + ahna
- the shared piece with madhyāhna — both end in “-ahna,” “day”
- the honest hedge — madhyāhna MAY also loosely cover “afternoon” in casual speech, but this is far less certain than Hindi's dopahar-widening story

Before you move on

What suffix does ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ share with ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ, and what does it mean? (-ಅಹ್ನ, -ahna, “day.”) What's the difference in their first pieces? (ಅಪರ, apara, “latter/further” vs. ಮಧ್ಯ, madhya, “middle.”) Is the claim that ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ also covers “afternoon” in casual speech as well-supported as Hindi's दोपहर-widening finding? (**No** — much more thinly sourced; treat it as a hedged possibility, not a settled fact.)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good morning in Kannada and judge when it will sound too formal.

Say ಶುಭೋದಯ — śubha + udaya, “auspicious rising” — and note the formal/written skew that makes ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ the safer casual morning greeting.

29.1 ಶುಭೋದಯ (śubhōdaya) — “good morning,” a third root for morning

You already have ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ, the everyday word for “morning.” This greeting reaches for a completely different word for the same idea — and, honestly, this lesson’s twist is about how uncertain its own “everyday” status turns out to be, once you look closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಶುಭೋದಯ (śubhōdaya) — “good morning” — is built from ಶುಭ (śubha, “good, auspicious”) plus ಉದಯ (udaya, “rising, sunrise,” from Sanskrit ud- “up” + i “to go” — the same root behind ಸೂರ್ಯೋದಯ, sūryōdaya, “sunrise” itself). This is a **completely different word** from ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (beḷagge, Chapter 26’s native “morning”) — Kannada now has (at least) two unrelated roots circling the idea of morning: one native (“the shining”), one Sanskrit (“the rising”).

Why it's said this way

Here's where this lesson needs real care. Some sources describe ಶುಭೋದಯ as the most common everyday way to say “good morning” in Kannada — but these are largely the same genre of generic phrasebook site whose claims about Hindi's सुप्रभात turned out, on closer inspection, to be overstated. A more careful source instead describes ಶುಭೋದಯ as reserved mainly for **formal or written** contexts — speeches, greeting cards, WhatsApp images — calling it “not as frequently used in daily conversations” as ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ/ನಮಸ್ತೆ, and at least one native-speaker account suggests casual spoken Kannada often reaches for **English** “good morning” instead of ಶುಭೋದಯ entirely. Taken together, this looks like the **same** formal/written skew already found for Hindi's सुप्रभात, not the genuine cross-language contrast a first pass at the sources might suggest. A native alternate, ಶುಭ ಮುಂಜಾನೆ (*śubha muñjāne*, using *muñjāne*, “the early morning, before sunrise”), also exists as a real, attested greeting construction — but its own register isn't independently confirmed here either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubhōdaya” — “good morning,” śubha + udaya
- the root contrast — beḷagge is native “shining”; udaya is Sanskrit “rising”
- the honest note — sources conflict, but the more careful ones point to the same formal/written skew already found for Hindi

Before you move on

Does ಶುಭೋದಯ share a root with ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ? (No — ಉದಯ, “rising,” is a completely different Sanskrit root from native ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ's “shining.”) Is ಶುಭೋದಯ genuinely common in everyday casual Kannada speech? (**Unclear, and possibly not** — sources conflict; the more careful ones describe it skewing formal/written, with ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ/ನಮಸ್ತೆ covering casual mornings instead, and one native-speaker account suggests English “good morning” often gets used in casual speech instead of ಶುಭೋದಯ entirely.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good evening in Kannada.

Say ಶುಭ ಸಂಜೆ, correct the common claim that ಸಂಜೆ is native Dravidian, and keep ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ as the all-hours fallback.

30.1 ಶುಭ ಸಂಜೆ (śubha sañje) — formal, and correctly citing where ಸಂಜೆ comes from

You already have ಸಂಜೆ, “evening” — and you already know it’s a Sanskrit word that arrived in Kannada already worn down, via Prakrit. Keep that fact straight here, since it’s an easy one to second-guess.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಶುಭ ಸಂಜೆ (śubha sañje) — “good evening” — pairs ಶುಭ (“good, auspicious”) with ಸಂಜೆ, the exact word from Chapter 27: Sanskrit ಸಂಧ್ಯಾ (saṃdhyā), borrowed into Kannada via **Maharashtri Prakrit** ಸಂಝಾ (sañjhā). You might run across a plausible-sounding claim elsewhere that ಸಂಜೆ is “native Dravidian” — it isn’t, and you already have the real answer from Chapter 27. Don’t let a claim that merely *sounds* plausible override something you’ve already verified.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s where this lesson needs to be careful about its own sourcing, not just the etymology’s. General impressions lean toward ಶುಭ ಸಂಜೆ skew-

ing **formal**, with the all-purpose ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ — or, among younger urban speakers, borrowed English “**hello**” — more likely to cover ordinary casual conversation. But the evidence for this specific register claim is genuinely **thin**: it’s the same kind of impression that, for both Hindi’s सुप्रभात and Kannada’s own ಶುಭೋದಯ, needed real digging to confirm or correct, and here that deeper digging hasn’t turned up anything more solid than a general leaning. Treat this as an open **question**, echoing the same one already raised for those two greetings, not a third confirmed data point — this lesson doesn’t have strong enough sourcing to settle it either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sañje” — “good evening,” a genuinely Sanskrit-rooted pairing
- the correction — ಸಂಜೆ is Sanskrit-via-Prakrit, NOT native Dravidian, whatever a plausible-sounding claim elsewhere might say
- ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ — the likely all-purpose everyday alternative, though this greeting’s own register remains an open question

Before you move on

Is ಸಂಜೆ native Dravidian? (**No** — Sanskrit ಸಂಧ್ಯಾ via Maharashtri Prakrit, already established in Chapter 27; be skeptical of any claim otherwise.) Is it settled that ಶುಭ ಸಂಜೆ is formal/rare in casual speech, the way सुप्रभात and ಶುಭೋದಯ turned out to be? (**Not settled** — the impression leans that way, with ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ likely covering casual use, but the sourcing here is too thin to call it confirmed.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good afternoon in Kannada, and fall back on ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ when I want a greeting that fits any hour.

Say ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ — built on the “noon” word rather than ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ — and reach instead for ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ, the greeting confirmed to work at any time of day.

31.1 ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ — good afternoon

Two lessons ago you met a careful hedge: does ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ, “noon,” also loosely cover “afternoon”? This greeting hands you a real data point.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (śubha madhyāhna) — “good afternoon” — is the standard greeting for this concept. Notice which noun it actually reuses: ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (madhyāhna, “noon,” Chapter 17) — **not** ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (aparāhna, the word Chapter 28 established as the more precisely “afternoon”-specific term). This is exactly the kind of concrete usage evidence that bears on Chapter 28’s own hedge: if the standard **greeting** for “good afternoon” reaches for *madhyāhna* rather than *aparāhna*, that’s a real (if still not fully conclusive) sign that *madhyāhna*’s job has genuinely stretched to cover the afternoon in everyday use, not just at noon itself.

Why it's said this way

Here's the useful discipline this lesson followed: checking a claim against an actual, directly fetched source page, not just trusting a search-engine's own summary of one. That check turned up **two** claims of very different strength. ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ's status as a genuinely **universal** greeting — suited to any time of day, any occasion — is independently confirmed across multiple fetched sources; that one's solid. The claim that ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ leans **formal or semi-formal** — workplaces, official meetings — traces back to just **one** source. It's a real, directly-verified data point, worth taking seriously — but it isn't cross-corroborated the way the ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ claim is, so treat it as a single well-checked impression, not a settled fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhna” — “good afternoon,” reusing the “noon” word, not “aparāhna”
- why that matters — real evidence for madhyāhna's meaning stretching to cover “afternoon”
- ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ — the confirmed universal, any-time-of-day greeting, cross-checked across multiple sources

Before you move on

Does ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ use ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (“noon”) or ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (the more precise “afternoon” word)? (ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ — real evidence for its meaning stretching to cover “afternoon” too.) Is the “formal/workplace” register claim for ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ as solidly confirmed as ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ's universal status? (**No** — the workplace claim rests on a single directly-verified source, not cross-corroborated the way ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ's is.) What's the confirmed universal, any-time-of-day alternative? (ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ.)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Kannada verb as stem plus tense plus person, swap the middle bead for the past, hear the p → h law that separates Kannada from its three sisters, and say why ಗೊತ್ತು carries no person at all.

Say ನನಗೆ ಗೊತ್ತು, name the three slots that built iruttēne, hōguttēne and nōḍuttēne, explain which slot ಗೊತ್ತು leaves empty and where its person went instead, and give the sound-law behind pōgu → hōgu.

32.1 ಇರು (iru) — “to be,” and the machine inside every Kannada verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. Kannada builds a verb the way you thread beads on a string, and this first verb carries the whole string.

You’ll want to know: ಇರು

ಇರು — *iru* — to be, to exist, to stay, to live

It is native Dravidian, from an old root meaning “be, remain, stay put.” Tamil kept the very same word, இரு (*iru*), and Malayalam has ഇരിക്കുക (*irikkuka*); Telugu went its own way with ఉండు (*undu*).

Iru is about **existing** or **being somewhere**, not about linking two nouns: “I am in Bangalore” takes *iru*, but “I am a teacher” takes no verb at all.

The letters in this word

ಇ (the standing vowel *i*) + ರು (*ru*) → ಇರು. Both shapes turned up already in ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*, “no”).

The form you hear most is ಇದ್ದೇನೆ (*iddēne*), “I am,” its ಧ್ವ held long — *id-dē-ne*. You have said it already, inside Chapter 3’s ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ (*cennāgiddēne*, “I’m well”).

Grammar Lens: stem, then tense, then person

English changes a verb by putting words **around** it: *I am, I was, I will be*. Kannada changes it by gluing pieces **onto the end** of it, always in the same order:

ಇರು + ಉತ್ತ + ಏನೆ → ಇರುತ್ತೇನೆ

iru (be) + *-utt-* (happening now) + *-ēne* (“I”) → *iruttēne*

Left to right: **be** — **present** — **I**, three slots welded into one word. Languages built this way are called **agglutinative**, from Latin *glutinare*, “to glue.”

Two payoffs at once. The last piece already means “I,” so *nānu* is optional. And nothing here belongs to *iru* alone: every verb in this chapter is the same three slots with a new first bead.

(*Iruttēne* is the regular build, “I stay, I will be”; *iddēne* is the same verb worn down onto its own past stem *idd-*, for “I am **right now**.”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iru” — be, exist, stay
- the three beads in order — “iru ... utt ... ēne”
- the sisters — Tamil “iru”, Malayalam “irikkuka”, Telugu “uṇḍu”

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of *iruttēne*, in order? (**Stem, tense, person** — *iru*, *-utt-*, *-ēne*.) Which piece carries “I”? (**The last one**, *-ēne* — which is why *nānu* can be dropped.) Which sister kept the same

verb unchanged, and which went its own way? (**Tamil** *iru*; **Telugu** *undu*.) Next: the sound-law that made Kannada sound unlike all three of its sisters.

32.2 ಹೋಗು (hōgu) — “to go,” and the law that made Kannada sound like Kannada

Keep the three beads and change only the first, and you have a new verb. But this first bead hides the single most useful sound-fact in the language.

You’ll want to know: ಹೋಗು

ಹೋಗು — *hōgu* — to go

ಹೋ (*ha* carrying the long-*ō* sign) + ಗು (*gu*). Thread the beads and you get ಹೋಗುತ್ತೇನೆ (*hōguttēne*), “I go” — *hōgu* + *-utt-* + *-ēne*, exactly the machine *iru* just handed you. The bare stem is already a command: *hōgu!*, “go!”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil’s word for “go” is போ / போகு (*pō / pōgu*). Kannada’s is *hōgu*, and that *h* is **not** a different root. Around a thousand years ago Kannada softened every old word-initial *p-* to *h-* — and Kannada is the **only** one of the four literary Dravidian languages that did it.

Once you know the law, whole shelves of vocabulary line up:

Tamil	Kannada	meaning
<i>pōgu</i>	<i>hōgu</i>	go
<i>pattu</i>	<i>hattu</i>	ten
<i>pāl</i>	<i>hālu</i>	milk
<i>peyar</i>	<i>hesaru</i>	name

You have met two of those already — *hattu* in Chapter 7, *hesaru* back in Chapter 2. One law, and both of them stop being coincidences.

The other two sisters kept the *p*: Telugu పోవు (*pōvu*), పది (*padi*, “ten”), పాలు (*pālu*, “milk”); Malayalam പോകുക (*pōkuka*), പത്ത് (*pattu*), പാൽ (*pāl*). A whole stripe of the family vocabulary, explained by one change only Kannada made.

The proof is written down: **Old Kannada** still spells these words with ಪ (pa), and the modern *h* is the later step. Nor has the law finished — in casual speech many speakers drop the *h* too, so *hōgu* can come out as *ōgu*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hōgu” — go — then “hōguttēne”, I go
- the three beads again — “hōgu ... utt ... ēne”
- the four pairs — “pōgu ... hōgu”, “pattu ... hattu”, “pāl ... hālu”, “peyar ... hesaru”
- the sisters that kept the p — Telugu “pōvu”, Malayalam “pōkuka”

Before you move on

Is Kannada’s *hōgu* a different root from Tamil’s *pōgu*? (**No** — the same old *p*, softened to *h*.) How many of the four sisters made that change? (**One** — Kannada alone.) Give two more pairs that follow the law. (*Pattu* / *hattu*, *pāl* / *hālu*, *peyar* / *hesaru*.) What do Old Kannada texts write instead of ಪ? (ಪ, pa.) Build “I go.” (*Hōguttēne*.)

32.3 ಬಾ (bā) — “come,” and the stem hiding underneath it

Every verb so far has been honest: the word you learn it by is the word the endings glue onto. This one is not — and Chapter 4’s goodbye has been quietly showing you why.

You’ll want to know: ಬಾ

ಬಾ — *bā* — come!

One letter and a vowel sign: ಬ (ba) with the long-ā stroke. As it stands it is a whole command — *bā!*, “come!” — the partner of *hōgu!* from Chapter 4.

But you cannot thread beads onto $b\bar{a}$. Underneath, the verb’s working stem is ಬರು- ($baru-$), and everything attaches to that:

$baru-$ + $-utt-$ + $-ēne$ → ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ ($baruttēne$), “I come.”

Grammar Lens: two shapes, one verb

Most Kannada verbs have nothing to hide. *Iru* gives *iruttēne*, *hōgu* gives *hōguttēne*; the name of the verb **is** the stem. A small handful do not, and $b\bar{a}$ is the one you will meet daily: **call it $b\bar{a}$, build on $baru-$** . That is exactly what Chapter 4’s farewell was made of:

ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ — *hōgi baruttēne* — “having gone, I come”
— “I’ll go and come back.”

Hōgi is *hōgu* in its “having ...-ed” form; *baruttēne* is *baru-* with the present bead and the “I” bead. Kannada refuses a bare goodbye, so it promises the return instead — and needs both verbs to do it.

Tamil splits the same verb the same way: வா ($v\bar{a}$) to call it by, வரு ($varu-$) to build on; Malayalam has വരുന്നു (*varuka*), Telugu వచ్చు (*vaccu*), whose command form is రా ($r\bar{a}$).

And notice Kannada’s b against Tamil’s v — a second Kannada-only habit, sitting right beside the $p \rightarrow h$ law:

Tamil	Kannada	meaning
$v\bar{a}$	$b\bar{a}$	come
$v\bar{a}y$	$b\bar{a}yi$	mouth

Two laws, both at the front of the word, both Kannada’s own. Between them they account for much of why Kannada does not sound like its sisters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ $b\bar{a}$ ” — come! — then the stem, “ $baru-$ ”
- “ $baruttēne$ ” — I come
- the farewell, taken apart — “ $hōgi$... $baruttēne$ ”
- the two Kannada laws together — “ $v\bar{a}$... $b\bar{a}$ ” and “ $pōgu$... $hōgu$ ”

Before you move on

You call this verb *bā* — so what do the endings actually attach to? (ಬರು-, *baru*-.). Build “I come.” (*Baruttēne*.) What are the two halves of *hōgi baruttēne*? (“**H**aving gone” and “**I** come” — Kannada promises the return instead of saying goodbye.) Kannada has *bā* where Tamil has *vā*: what change is that? (**W**ord-initial *v*- became *b*-.). Next: the middle bead.

32.4 ತಿನ್ನು (tinnu) — “to eat,” and the bead that carries time

Hold the first and last beads still and swap only the middle one. That is almost the whole of Kannada tense — almost, because one of the three times you expect is missing.

You’ll want to know: ತಿನ್ನು

ತಿನ್ನು — *tinnu* — to eat

ತಿ (*ta* with the short-*i* sign) + ನ್ನು (a doubled *n* with *u*), the ನ್ನ held long — *tin-nu*.

It is Proto-Dravidian, an old root meaning simply “eat,” and here the family agrees: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Malayalam തിന്നുക (*tinnuka*). Tamil has the root as தின் (*tin*) — but narrowed it to chewing and snacking, handing everyday eating to சாப்பிடு (*sāppidu*).

For a **full meal**, Kannada reaches instead for ಉಟ ಮಾಡು (*ūṭa māḍu*), “to do a meal” — the same noun-plus-*māḍu* trick that built *kelasa māḍu*, “to work,” in Chapter 5.

Grammar Lens: one bead for the past, and a future that never separated

Hold the stem *tinn-* and the person bead *-ēne* fixed, and let the middle piece do the work:

when	Kannada
now	<i>tinnuttēne</i>
already	<i>tinde</i>
tomorrow	<i>tinnuttēne</i> — again

The past bead is a **-d-**: *tin* + *-d-* + *-e* → ತಿಂದೆ (*tinde*), “I ate.” One consonant of difference between two pieces that never moved. English needs a whole new shape (*ate*); Kannada needs one bead. Now the surprise in the third row. Everyday Kannada keeps **no** separate future — the *-utt-* bead covers both:

ನಾಳೆ ತಿನ್ನುತ್ತೇನೆ — *nāḷe tinnuttēne* — “I’ll eat **tomorrow**.”

The time-word *nāḷe* does the work the verb declines to do. Kannada **has** a distinct future bead, *-uv-* — ತಿನ್ನುವೆನು (*tinnuvenu*) — but you will meet it in writing far more often than in conversation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tinnu” — eat — then “tinnuttēne”, I eat
- the past — “tinde”, I ate
- tomorrow, with the same present bead — “nāḷe tinnuttēne”
- the full meal instead — “ūṭa māḍu”

Before you move on

Which of the three beads changes for tense? (**The middle one.**) Say “I ate.” (*Tinde* — the past bead is a *-d-*.) How does everyday Kannada say “I will eat”? (**With the present bead**, *tinnuttēne*, plus a time-word like *nāḷe*.) Which sister narrowed this root away from everyday eating? (**Tamil** — *sāppiḍu* took over.) Next: the third slot, and a word where the four sisters genuinely part company.

32.5 ನೋಡು (nōḍu) — “to see,” and the last bead of all

First bead, the verb. Middle bead, the time. One slot is left — the one that lets Kannada drop “I,” “you” and “she” altogether.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನೋಡು — *nōḍu* — to see, to look

ನೋ (*na* with the long-*ō* sign) + ಡು (*ḍu*, tongue curled back — the retroflex *ḍ*, not an English *d*).

Nōḍu is native Dravidian, close kin to Tamil’s நோக்கு (*nōkku*, “to look”) — though the exact reconstruction is not fully settled.

What is settled is stranger. Every sister has a native Dravidian everyday word for “see,” and **no two chose the same one**: Kannada ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), Tamil பார் (*pār*), Telugu చూడు (*cūḍu*), Malayalam കാണുക (*kāṇuka*). Four inherited roots, one meaning each — a genuine split, like the cat-word in Chapter 21.

And the passed-over roots did not vanish. Kannada still has ಕಾಣು (*kāṇu*) — Malayalam’s very root — with a different job: “to **appear**, to be visible.”

Grammar Lens: the third slot, and where gender lives

Hold *nōḍutt-* still and swap only the last bead:

who	Kannada
I	<i>nōḍuttēne</i>
you, familiar	<i>nōḍuttīya</i>
you, respectful	<i>nōḍuttīri</i>
he	<i>nōḍuttāne</i>
she	<i>nōḍuttāle</i>
they	<i>nōḍuttāre</i>

Six endings, and they are not *nōḍu*’s — they are the same six on every verb in this chapter. Learn them once and the other five come free.

Two things worth naming. **Gender lives only in the third person** — *-āne* he, *-āle* she; *nōḍuttēne* is the same word whoever says it. And **the respectful *-ttīri* is the plural ending**, the same plural-for-respect you met at *nīvu*, sitting inside Chapter 3’s ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? (*nīvu hēgiddīrā?*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nōḍu*” — see — then “*nōḍuttēne*”, I see

- the six endings — “ēne ... īya ... īri ... āne ... āle ... āre”
- the four sisters’ four see-words — “nōḍu ... pār ... cūḍu ... kāṇuka”
- the same six beads on another verb — “hōguttēne ... hōguttāne ... hōguttāre”

Before you move on

Which slot does the last bead fill? (**Person** — which is why the pronoun can be dropped.) In which person does Kannada mark gender? (**The third** only.) Do the four sisters share an everyday word for “see”? (**No** — *nōḍu*, *pār*, *cūḍu*, *kāṇuka*, four different native roots.) What job does *kāṇu* do in Kannada? (“To **appear**.”) Next: a know-word with no beads at all.

32.6 ಗೊತ್ತು (gottu) — “known,” the word with no beads at all

Five verbs, every one ending on a bead that meant “I.” The last word of the chapter has no such bead — and Chapter 6 handed you the sentence it makes, whole, before you could take it apart.

You’ll want to know: ಗೊತ್ತು

ಗೊತ್ತು — *gottu* — **known**

ಗೊ (*ga* with the short-*o* sign) + ತ್ತು (a doubled *t* with *u*), the ತ್ತ held long — *got-tu*.

And here is the catch: *gottu* is **not a verb**. It is a noun-like word meaning “known, settled, fixed.” No stem slot, no tense bead, no person bead — and it never changes shape.

ನನಗೆ ಗೊತ್ತು. — *nanage gottu*. — literally “**to-me** [it is] **known**.”

Grammar Lens: no person slot, so the person moves out

Chapter 6 told you *nānu* was gone and the dative *nanage* stood in its place. Now you can see **why**: a person bead needs a verb to sit on, and *gottu* is not one. So the knower is pushed outside the word entirely:

- *nanage gottu* — known **to me**
- *ninage gottu* — known **to you**
- *avanige gottu* — known **to him**

Only the little dative word changes. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry: five verbs carried the person in the ending, so *nānu* could be dropped; here the ending carries no person, so the dative word is the one thing you **cannot** drop.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kannada does have proper verbs for knowing, both native Dravidian. ತಿಳಿ (*tīli*, “to become clear”) takes all three beads — ತಿಳಿಯುತ್ತದೆ (*tīliyuttade*). ಅರಿ (*ari*, “to perceive”) survives mostly in writing.

Both have cousins: *tīli* answers Tamil தெளி (*teḷi*) and Telugu తెలియ (*telīyu*), everyday form తెలుసు (*telusu*); *ari* answers Tamil அறி (*ari*) and Malayalam അറിയുക (*ariyuka*). Underneath, this family’s word for “know” usually means “**become clear**” — and all four sisters put the knower in the dative, exactly as Chapter 6’s table showed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gottu” — known — then “nanage gottu”, I know
- the three knowers, one unchanged word — “nanage ... ninage ... avanige gottu”
- the five that carried the person — “iruttēne, hōguttēne, baruttēne, tinnuttēne, nōduttēne”

Before you move on

Is *gottu* a verb? (**No** — a noun-like word meaning “known, settled,” with none of the three beads.) So where does the knower go, and why? (**Into the dative**, *nanage* — there is no person slot for it.) Say “I know.” (*Nanage gottu*.) Name the three slots one last time. (**Stem, tense, person** — *nōḍu* + *-utt-* + *-ēne*.) And the law behind *pōgu* → *hōgu*? (**Initial p-** became **h-** — in Kannada alone.)

The Kannada script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ಕ = ka, ಮ = ma, ರ = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ಕಾ = kā, ಕಿ = ki, ಕೀ = kī, ಕು = ku, ಕೂ = kū, ಕೆ = ke, ಕೇ = kē, ಕೊ = ko, ಕೋ = kō, ಕೌ = kau.
3. **A *virama* strips the built-in vowel, and the bare consonant *stacks under the next* as a conjunct (*ottakṣara*):** ನೆ + ಕೆ → ನ್ಕೆ (ska), ನೆ + ಯೆ → ನ್ಯೆ (nya), ಲ + ಲ → ಳ (lla). This stacking is a signature of the Kannada–Telugu scripts.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

ಅ a · ಆ ā · ಇ i · ಈ ī · ಉ u · ಊ ū · ಎ e · ಏ ē · ಐ ai · ಒ o · ಓ
ಒ · ಔ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration is written.** ಕೆ k / ಖೆ kh, ದೆ d / ಧೆ dh — the “h” is a real puff. (Unlike Tamil, Kannada keeps separate letters for the Sanskrit aspirates and voiced stops, because it borrowed so many Sanskrit words.)
- **Round forms.** Kannada letters are rounded and looping — developed for writing on palm-leaf, where straight strokes would split the leaf. Telugu, its closest script-sister, shares the look.

Kannada in the Dravidian family

Kannada is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages (with Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam) — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one (English, Latin, Sanskrit). It shares the grammar and much native vocabulary with its sisters, but — like Telugu, and unlike Tamil — it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Kannada words are home-grown (*haudu*, *illa*, *sari*) and which came from Sanskrit (*namaskāra*, *dhanyavāda*).